



**LIFE CHANGING: Villagers of Hari Ram Pura watching TV at night, a new luxury**

mend their ways. Eight hundred villages in Bharatpur were given uninterrupted power which was later disconnected in six hundred fifty-two villages. It made no difference. She then ordered power to be disconnected, including in 166 villages in Dholpur, where she is the erstwhile maharani from.

Three months of darkness were enough for the villagers to see the light. Last week, the villagers found their connections restored, but with a warning that if power losses exceeded 15 per cent again, disconnection would be swift. This is part of Raje's effort to push the implementation of Rs 4,000 crore power reforms, mainly the feeder renovation programme. Of the 8,475 feeders in the state, 5,571 have been renovated, which means 22,280 villages are getting minimum 20 hours of residential supply every day and four-six hours of agricultural supply. The target is to cover all 35,000 villages by July end. The programme is aimed at segregating supplies for agriculture and domestic purposes to ensure that heavily subsidised power for agriculture was not diverted for domestic or commercial usage. The secondary aim is to curb power theft. Most distribution networks have been reinforced with insulated and specially armoured cables to bring down the incidents of

illegal connections. One transformer has been installed for every two agriculture connections. Residential connections have smaller transformers, each supplying electricity to two dozen houses for 20 hours or more. The supply is metered at each transformer to identify the cluster of houses where consumption is higher than recorded in their meters. This has effectively curbed the diversion of agricultural power for residential usage.

Raje had pushed the programme hard immediately after taking over four-and-a-half years ago arguing that curbing transmission losses was a better option than raising power tariffs. It would also improve the quality and duration of supply. She rejected suggestions by power officials to hike

**EMPOWERED: Due to constant power, Roop Singh, a welder from Chiksana can work for longer hours**



the rates, except for a one-time nominal increase. In most areas, an improved power supply has seen losses falling. This is quite an achievement considering the huge losses due to theft earlier. As a result, the state now has 99 per cent of power bills being paid. Tamper-proof meters have been installed outside homes, in the open. Special vigilance posts have been set up to book the culprits. Over a thousand were arrested before the illegal activity came to a stop. More than this though, a few months of adequate supply has made villagers realise the difference it has made to the quality of their lives. Because of lights in homes and streets,

the crime rate has dropped and students can study at night. Families can watch television till late.

The initial success of the programme has prompted the state Government to dangle some more carrots. Villages exceeding the population of 5,000 will get three-phase round-the-clock supply instead of single phase if they continue to show reduction in power losses. "We will be a power surplus state by next year," Raje says, adding, "by August, it will be Diwali every night for the first time ever in the state." Villagers are also getting used to paying more for longer hours of power. Laxmi Devi, sarpanch of Bachamadi village in Bharatpur, says longer usage has resulted in her bills, which are bi-monthly, increasing to Rs 2,000 from Rs 500 but the ones not complaining are people like electrician

Mahesh of Chiksana village, who is getting more business now, as is Roop Singh, a welder from the same village who can now work for longer hours. The biggest benefit for all is a regular supply of water during fixed hours.

Power reforms are never easy but to take such drastic steps with state elections a few months away was a huge gamble. For Raje, like the rest of the state, it could even mean a return to power. ■